

FROM RESOLUTIONS TO MOTIONS: MOVING IN A DIFFERENT DIRECTION

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Abstract: The World Universities Debating Championship (WUDC) format is growing around the world, especially in the USA. This format is very different from more traditional American formats. One of the major differences is the topic for the debate, known in WUDC debating as the “motion” for the debate. There are crucial differences in how these topics (or motions) are used by tournament organizers and debaters, as well as how they are developed and tested. The paucity of published material on this subject reflects the fact that most debating programs outside the USA are not based in academic departments, thus there is little incentive for scholarly work by faculty in this area. Given these major differences, it is important for American coaches and debaters to understand the both the existing standards for writing debate topics for American formats as well as guidelines that have been developed for creating effective motions for good WUDC debates. Finally, this paper explores how to develop, test and deploy motions successfully as part of a WUDC debate tournament.

When you ask someone if they want to go and see a debate, the first thing they ask is, “What will be debated?” As professionals, we often forget that this is, for the general population, the most important feature that might “hook” people into actually watching a competitive debate. Formats and styles come and go, but what is to be debated remains important.

The World Universities Debating Championship (WUDC, also known as “British Parliamentary” or simply “BP”) format is the most commonly used format for international competitive debating. It has grown phenomenally in recent years. This debating format is now becoming increasingly popular in the United States. It is important to realize that the organizing

metaphor of American debating is very different from the vision that applies to global debating that did not evolve from the American model. WUDC, or BP, has many differences with native debating formats in the United States. One of the most important differences is the topic for the debate, called a “motion.” What will actually be debated about in a WUDC debate, i.e. “the motion,” is critical to the entire experience. A poorly framed motion can significantly impact the experience of everyone at a competition, especially given that debaters have only fifteen minutes to prepare. If the debate motion is poorly understood, unbalanced, trivial or confusing, the educational opportunities of the debaters and judges are seriously degraded. It would behoove the WUDC to develop strong standards and practices of motion construction.

Topics are handled differently in different debate formats. It would be worthwhile to examine this process and how it differs and has changed through time. In a Cross Examination Debate Association debate contest the topic is set for the year. According to Snider (2008), “Every year high school or university policy debate uses a different topic or resolution. The affirmative must develop specific policies (plans) that support the topic or resolution” (p. 70). The Cross Examination Debate Association carries out the process of topic selection (Cross Examination Debate Association, 2015).

In the American Parliamentary Debate Association (APDA) format, when the pairings for the debates are announced the “resolution” is also announced. The resolution is “a phrase or sentence that forms the starting point for the debate” (American Parliamentary Debate Association, 2014)). While it is entirely appropriate for the proposition or government team to focus on the resolution, it is not really mandatory. Most teams use a “loose link” approach where the team

makes only a passing connection to the resolution. Often the resolution is something outrageous, such as “Attack dogs have all the fun.” But, the proposition team can, for example, propose under this resolution that “each New York City police officer be required to spend one day a year in a public school teaching students about their rights under the constitution.” The official rules make it clear that the use of this example would be appropriate, and that this loose link approach “will often be unrelated to the case statement of the government” (American Parliamentary Debate Association, 2014). More likely, no resolution will be read and each government/proposition team will select the topic to be debated.

While the APDA is a healthy and high quality format, it is not very large and serves a smaller number of schools. A larger, similar format is the National Parliamentary Debate Association (NPDA). The NPDA emerged as an “idea” among some debate coaches and debaters in 1991 as a reaction to the lack of public accessibility for CEDA debate, and in 1994 it staged its first national tournament (Johnson, 1999).

By 1999 there was a movement for change in NPDA procedure that led to the creation of the National Parliamentary Tournament of Excellence (NPTE) which would be a more “sophisticated” format, only allowing teams to enter who had shown considerable success in NPDA contests. The NPDA format had been changing through the adoption of more “debate jargon” in the vocabulary of the contest, more prepared cases, and an increase in the amount of procedural arguments. By 2008 Kevin Minch, NPDA president, had to admit that

a growing elite circuit in parliamentary debate, with all of the unique challenges that competitiveness brings, has pushed an element of

the NPDA community out of parliamentary debate altogether and has helped to produce a form of debate that is largely unrecognizable to those who embraced the format in the early 1990s. Because NPTE and NPDA share a common circuit, the drive among many participants has been to remake NPDA in NPTE's image. (Minch, 2008)

In 2008, the worry was that many programs were leaving to try other formats (such as WUDC) that were more pedagogically and philosophically consistent with the reasons that these programs joined NPDA. Minch wrote, "These departures include founding programs and directors, long-term organizational stalwarts, former Presidents, and former national champions" (Minch, 2008). The idea of the NPTE had begun in 1999 and by 2001 the first national tournament had been held (NPTE, 2015).

One of the most important changes brought to NPDA debate by the NPTE was the adoption of "controversy areas." Topics for all debates were drawn from an area of controversy. This allowed teams to do extensive research before the tournament and use that research in the debates. As the NPTE rules state, "The Topic Committee will make resolutions exclusively using the agent, direction of action and what the actor will be doing as noted in the Controversy Areas. An example resolution for the Somalia Controversy Area released at the tournament before Prep Time would be: The U.S. federal government should halt its air strikes in Somalia" (NPTE, 2015).

While the NPDA had been founded on a basis of purely "extemporaneous" topics (Branham & Meany, 1998), by 2009 the NPDA rules for competition had adopted this controversy area procedure, and it is still in effect as of the most recent rules in 2014

(National Parliamentary Debate Association, 2014). Individual tournaments have mostly followed this lead in using controversy areas. For example, the Western Washington tournament limited the controversy area to, "ideas and issues raised in the State of the Union address" (Western Washington Univ. Speech and Debate, 2015). An invitation to a 2015 regional championship was broader:

Topic areas will be released to the attending schools after the deadline for registration. It is important to note that all topics will come from the topic areas only. This being said it is encouraged that all schools in attendance research all possible sides of the topic area. (Walters State College, 2015)

The 2012 NPTE had "four broad topic areas from which individual resolutions were drawn for each of the debates at the 2012 NPTE," including protection of marine natural resources, sovereignty of European Union member states, United States tax policy, and humanitarian assistance and/or public health efforts in North Africa (Washburn University, 2012). The 2015 invitation to the NPTE was even more specific. Instead of controversy areas; there were specific topics that were circulated for research:

Preliminary and Elimination 1-2 Debates. Each of the six preliminary round and elimination 1-2 debates shall use a single resolution from the controversy areas. These resolutions shall be taken from the list of nine resolutions identified by the topic committee as preliminary or early elimination round resolutions. Elimination 3-8 Debates. In each of the elimination 3-8 debates, a single, previously unused resolution drawn from the controversy areas shall be used. (NPTE, 2015)

Both major parliamentary debate formats in

America had now departed from the extemporaneous model of debating. In APDA, debate teams write cases before the tournament and “loose link” them as necessary in each debate. In NPDA and NPTE debate, extemporaneous debate has been replaced by a set of controversies and topic areas. An April 2015 essay in *The Federalist* notes that as of 2015 the topic is not adhered to in most formats. The NPTE final round, the NPDA final round and the CEDA final round all featured debates that were almost totally divorced from the stated topic (Curtis, 2015). It seems that America had a hard time embracing extemporaneous debating.

In the 21st century, World Universities Debating Championship (or “worlds”) format had begun to expand in America. While some schools have done this format for a long time, many other schools began to desert NPDA-NPTE and policy debate, while more added worlds competition to their tournament mix. By 2015 the largest national tournament of any of the formats was at the Worlds-format United States Universities Debate Championship, with 172 teams in Anchorage, Alaska. (Llano, 2015)

In a World Universities Debating Championship debate, the role of the motion of the debate is quite different. Each debate has a different motion and preparation is strictly regulated. According to the Berlin WUDC (2013) Novice Briefing:

Each round has a specific topic. This topic will be announced to all participants 15 minutes before debates begin. Teams may only prepare in their teams – i.e. the two speakers in a team may confer with each other ONLY while preparing. Teams may not use any electronic devices to aid them in their preparation, with the exception of stopwatches (the use of mobile phones is allowed only insofar

as the phone is used as a stopwatch) and electronic dictionaries. (p. 2)

The motion for the debate is also a secret in advance and compiled by tournament administrators, known as Chief Adjudicators. As Harvey-Smith (2011) puts it:

The Chief Adjudicator, aided by her DCAs, is responsible for setting all of the motions. Secrecy is important, as debaters must not find out about a motion before it is announced. Therefore, the number of people who know the topics should be kept to an absolute minimum. (p. 143)

For a short explanation of this format, one can examine a briefing from the WUDC world tournament itself.

Before discussing standards to be used in drafting and testing motions for WUDC debate competitions, it is important to understand the differences between this and other American debate formats.

The differences between WUDC and other American formats are more than just the name, topic or resolution versus motion, but in almost everything about the topic for a given debate. A motion in WUDC debate is to be used only once. In a tournament there will be a new motion for every round of debating. While various tournaments around the world may copy motions from other regions, and while some motions are considered “classic” and may be used more often, debaters cannot predict what they will be debating about with any confidence. While in the United States formats, such as CEDA, a topic may last an entire academic year, the motion in WUDC debating is a transitory entity. This means that within the fifteen minutes of preparation time the teams must be able to quickly evaluate the

issues of the motion, draw on information such as almanacs and briefing books on current events, and construct arguments as needed.

This “extemporaneous” nature of WUDC debate is worth considering as one of its most valuable features. As someone interested in imparting “real life” applicable skills to debaters, this element of the format is incredibly important. Many speech communication scholars through the years have agreed that training in “extemporaneous” speaking is one of the most valuable things that forensics has to offer. Kelly (2010), in a report for the National Forensic Association, pointed out this broad agreement:

Offering education opportunities in speaking with limited preparation provides students with valuable practice in the most common, practical and useful realms of public speech. In reference to extemporaneous speaking, O’Hair, Stewart and Rubenstein (2004) observe, “Probably more public speeches - from business presentations to formal public addresses - are delivered by extemporaneous delivery than by any other method” (p. 255). Zarefsky (2007) comments, “[t]his mode is recommended for most speakers and speeches because it encourages a conversational quality and is flexible enough to permit adaptation to feedback” (p. 253-54). Beebe and Beebe (2000) conclude, “extemporaneous speaking is the approach most communication teachers recommend for most situations” (p. 280).

Extemporaneous speech delivery has been seen as a beneficial skill in political and public affairs. Citizens are called on to discuss these issues in conversation, at citizen meetings and at other less than formal gatherings as well as on more formal occasions. The

skill at discussing these issues in an extemporaneous manner can be extremely valuable. Preston (1991) has identified extemporaneous speaking about current issues to have considerable practical benefits for citizens, such as how current events shape economic realities, how legal changes influence events and everyday life, the rapidly changing factors involved in career choice, and understanding how to use known facts in the acts of citizenship (p.12). Preston concludes that extemporaneous advocacy helps speakers conduct a reality test on the information that they already have. WUDC debate provides an important opportunity for debaters to depart from other American debate formats. In doing so it prepares them for future communication experiences in important civic roles.

Each WUDC tournament will draft the motions they will use in advance of the actual event and keep them secret. A group made up of those with experience in debating usually drafts the motions. Often, they are individuals who have been selected as “Chief Adjudicator” or “Deputy Chief Adjudicators” for the event. They will trade ideas, discuss the “debatability” of the motions, and finalize them before the tournament. This selection may take place months in advance or on the day of the tournament. The motions selected may represent the experience and/or interests of those selecting them. There are very few tournaments that have a “theme” for their motions, unlike the controversy areas and motion lists of NPDA and NPTE. Debaters may inspect the backgrounds of those who are writing the motions (perhaps the chief adjudicator is an economist) and try and infer motions from these facts. But these efforts, while occasionally useful, are rarely very productive in guiding preparation.

This is very different from other formats. In the

Cross Examination Debate Association, individuals in the community may draft topic area papers to discuss a possible area that a topic could be found. Topic areas are then reviewed and one is selected by vote of member schools. A topic committee, elected by the members, draft a number of topics (often using a final in-person meeting of the committee) and then present them to the community. The members vote on these suggested topics, and one topic is then chosen to be debated during the entire academic year. Policy debate topics tend to be very broad so that debating one topic for the entire year does not become boring, and teams that support the topic do not have to advocate the entire statement of the topic. Likewise, at NPDA and NPTE tournaments there are committees that draft controversy areas and possible topics, but these individual tournaments may well mirror the WUDC practice, with the exception that in WUDC the motions are never known until immediately before the debate.

The motion for a WUDC debate is a one-off event that may only be repeated rarely at a different tournament. A glance at some of the major websites that track and compile motions will make this clear, such as Debate Motion Central, European Debating and Debate-info.

Instead of researching topics that have been announced, WUDC debaters focus on the most current set of news events and controversies in anticipation of motions about them. CEDA debaters research after the topic is announced, while WUDC debaters do research about motions that have yet to be used but can be inferred based on current events. Quite often the motions come from stories in the current news, such as conflict flash points or emerging social and political controversies.

The notion that WUDC debate “does not involve research” is untrue. Debaters that aim for success have regular briefing sessions, develop tools for following news stories and news trends, and design methods to absorb this information, not just catalog it. When a motion is given, debaters have fifteen minutes to prepare for the debate, so information needs to be at their command. Quite often programs will assign “position papers” to the student debaters, who then produce two or three page documents that other debaters read before a tournament even if they do not consult them in too much detail during specific debate preparation. There are numerous resources for such efforts to gather relevant knowledge and follow the news productively, such as one created by Australian debaters (Wu, 2015), members-only reading groups on Facebook with links to relevant articles, and a page to easily survey global sources of information, such as “News for Debaters” (Snider, 2015). Thus, WUDC pre-debate research is pre-emptory and general, while research methods in CEDA policy debate are reactive and specific.

The debaters at a WUDC tournament may come from many different countries. Even when the debaters are mostly from one country, such as the USA, the focus of the motions will be international, and even those concerning events inside a society will be worded in such a way that the debate is encouraged to deal with these issues as they play out in a variety of societies. There is an open recognition and encouragement that motions be debated in an international context. The briefings for judges and debaters given at the world championships make it clear that the motion is not to be debated in a “place set” or “time set” manner (Berlin WUDC Adjudicator Briefing, 2013). This means that the motions should be accessible to a global

audience, and words in motions must be carefully chosen. For example, the word “family” may be used in a motion, but the meaning of this word may be different in American, Asian and African societies in terms of how many generations are included. Those drafting the motions are often from different nations but, in any case, are expected to be aware of the need to relate the motions to a truly global audience of debaters. It is an aspirational goal and it is very true of major tournaments and the United States Universities Debating Championship.

The topic for a CEDA debate, on the other hand, is almost always set in the United States and has as the agent of action the “United States federal government.” This is understandable because this format of debating is almost exclusively taking place in the United States, while one of the attractions of WUDC debate is the opportunity for international competition. Thus, CEDA topics are for debating from an American perspective, while motions for WUDC debate are for debating from an international perspective.

The vast majority of topics for policy debate and CEDA (National Debate Tournament, 2015) have been about what policies governments should enact. Motions for WUDC debates tend to be far more varied. Often, the motions can be split into at least three groups, such as “fact,” “value,” and “policy,” which Americans have traditionally embraced (Wood, 1972). There is also a distinction between “open,” “closed,” and “semi-closed” motions. Open motions are vague in terms of the specifics for the debate (“This House believes the grass is greener on the other side”), while a closed motion is very clear on the subject for the debate even if there is still some room for interpretation. An examination of motions posted at the websites mentioned above indicates that the vast majority of motions for WUDC

debate tournaments are now “closed” or “semi-closed.”

In the early days of competitive debating in America the distinctions were between topics of fact and topics of policy, as well as local versus national topics. A survey carried out in 1930 (before there were national topics) of one hundred and fifty high school debate coaches indicated that there was a preference for policy topics and for local topics. “The first conclusion merely confirms present practice; probably six out of every ten questions debated by high school teams are questions of policy. The second endorses a commendable movement to make debating a real force in the individual community” (Howes, 1931).

The largest and most common debating format in the world, WUDC, should have a well-developed literature for motion construction. The act of motion construction occurs many times for each tournament and few motions are used with great repetition. If one seeks guidance on how to frame motions for WUDC debate, however, the search can be fairly difficult. There is a paucity of useful standards for motion construction. There seem to be some clear reasons as to why this is true.

Unlike American university debate programs, most WUDC debate programs are not located in academic departments. While CEDA teams usually find themselves hosted within a Speech Communication or related department, most international debate teams are clubs made up of students who have created these associations completely independent of formal academic departments (Bibby, 2011). It is no wonder, then, that there is a small emphasis on publication and research on motion building practices. It is faculty who tend to generate most of the academic publications on debate in the USA, as they have vocational incentives

to do so, while students have fewer of those incentives. There are also far fewer academic journals that are available for WUDC debate enthusiasts, with the main journal being the Monash Debate Review (2014), which refers to itself as “the world’s only international, peer reviewed debating journal.” With few professional incentives for debate theorizing and only one journal, the lack of scholarly discussion of motion drafting standards is not surprising.

Those who compose motions for WUDC tournaments tend to be a transitory population, in that they are involved for a few years and then leave involvement in WUDC debating. An outstanding debater may become a respected judge, and then may be selected to serve as a chief adjudicator or a deputy chief adjudicator, and thus compose motions for competition. Without a documented written record of their lessons and accomplishments, it is difficult to build a knowledge base on motion construction.

Despite these limitations, there is an emerging set of standards to guide WUDC debaters and organizers in drafting motions for competition. It is hoped that the following synthesis of traditional American standards and emerging WUDC standards can be of use for Americans (and others) who will be drafting motions for this rapidly growing activity.

American debate has already developed very sound standards for debate topic composition, but many of them seem to have been lost by modern practitioners. James O’Neill (1920) developed a fairly comprehensive list of guidelines for a good proposition for debate. These included:

1. It should be an assertion;
2. It should cover a single major issue;

3. It should be framed in unambiguous language;
4. It should be framed in unprejudiced language;
5. It should be as concrete and specific as possible;
6. It should place the burden of proof on the affirmative;
7. It should be as brief and simple as possible;
8. It should be debatable; and
9. It should be interesting.

Many other earlier American debate educators had very similar standards, but none quite as complete as O’Neill’s. These included A. Craig Baird (1928), Ray Immel and Ruth Whipple (1929), and Waldo Wilhoft (1929). One wonders where these standards went in the intellectual collective memory of American debate when in 2003 the NPDA provided the following guidelines for writing topics, which are not nearly as comprehensive. These included:

1. Timeliness – topics should be concurrent with social, political, and global events that challenge debaters’ awareness and articulation of social consciousness.
2. Fairness and debatability – topics should be balanced and not markedly privilege one side over another; topics should encourage good debate through the testing of general knowledge and equal opportunity; topics should be guided and specific in order to facilitate fairness and debatability.
3. Diversity and innovativeness – national tournament topics should represent a challenge to debaters while offering variety in form, content, and style of resolution.
4. Clarity of ground – topics should provide a clear

starting point for both sides of the debate. (Margesson, 2003)

I propose guidelines for motion construction that have been based on experience of those engaging in the process for the WUDC debate environment. These are not meant to be totalizing or absolute, but they hopefully provide a starting point for motion construction (Snider, 2014, p. 2). They include:

1. Elegance – use fewer words whenever possible to simplify understanding by competitors.
2. Focus - Concentrate on only one or two issues in the wording of a motion to avoid cognitive clutter.
3. Clarity - Avoid the use of ambiguous words.
4. Interest – Pick some motion areas that will be of interest to the population that is actually debating.
5. Ground – Make the division of ground clear as to what each side in the debate is defending.
6. Information – Given that the model for a WUDC debate is that the “intelligent citizen” should be the role for judges and debaters, one should expect that such a person would know something about the motion, and that the issues can be meaningfully discussed in the absence of expert knowledge.
7. Repetition – While “classic” motions can be repeated, it is expected that those attending a given tournament have not debated the same motion recently.
8. Depth – a motion must be deep enough for four different teams to have access to strong

arguments for eight different speeches. Thus, being able to identify five such major arguments for each side is a minimum requirement for depth.

9. Global – Motions for WUDC debates should have global focus, although at times an issue important to the region where the competition is being held may be used as well, but sparingly. For example, the final round in Ireland (Debate-Info, 2014, Cork) concerned abortion rights and the final round in India (Debate-Info, 2014, Chennai) concerned the proper economic model for the development of the Indian economy.

The procedure, as indicated previously, can be wildly variable. Discussions of such procedures seem to encourage an emphasis on time for planning and consideration as well as a personal distancing by individuals doing the drafting.

As suggested by Shengwu Li (2012), motions should not be a personal expression of preference by those drafting them, but instead an effort to provide ground for meaningful debates. Li suggests that if there is a motion committee each member should not get a “quota” of the motions to be used in the tournament. The focus should be on the best motion, not “your motion.” Likewise, if some area is a favorite of a member of the motion committee, and they would enjoy proposing such a motion, that does not mean that it is a good motion.

As a contemplative process, sufficient time should be taken to draft motions before the tournament. I have suggested (2014) starting months (if possible) in advance. Those involved should each submit a list of potential motions, and a longer list is better than a shorter list. The combined list would then be sorted

into categories (economics, human rights, etc.). Then, those considering the motions start by eliminating some motions and indicating those that are their favorites. Once the larger list becomes much smaller the testing options suggested by Shengwu Li should be used. Motions should get reworded and reconstructed as needed. Eventually, there is a list of motions just slightly larger than the numbers of debates to take place at the tournament and that are a fair representation of various categories. One or two extra motions should be ready to use just in case events change the status of one motion or if members decide there are problems with a motion that they had previously not foreseen.

Once the motions have been chosen, they need to be sequenced sensibly. There should be a purpose to the order in which motions are debated instead of just offering them randomly. I suggested several guidelines (2014):

1. There should be a variety of “types” of motions, such a fact, value, policy, etc. this makes sure that debaters learn how to deal with a variety of different questions, as opposed to the same “governments should do a policy” every debate.
2. There should be a variety of issue areas (international relations, animal rights, etc.). This makes sure that no one area of knowledge that a student might have because of their study of a specialty, such as economics or philosophy will be privileged.
3. Some (but very few) motions should be relevant to the location or the focus of the tournament. This might be advisable for the final round. For example, the Pan American Universities Debate Championship in 2015 had a final round motion about a Western Hemisphere free trade area.

4. Early debates, especially the first round, should be simpler. In this round the teams are randomly sorted, so a motion that is too complex might make it difficult for some teams to establish a good debate from the first government position and the abilities of the teams might be very disparate.
5. The final round motion should be planned as if it were a major public debate, as more people than any other debate will probably attend it. It should be something that hosts, sponsors and interested others might be interested in.

Once a body of motions have been assembled, it is important to actually test them before using them in competition.

While every tournament’s motion setting procedures will be different, there have been some very positive suggestions as to how to do this process. I argue that tournaments that have excellent motions are tournaments that have devoted a lot of time to drafting motions (months instead of the few days before the tournament) and may have actually debated the motions out informally to see what happens.

At a very basic level, motions need to be amenable to treatment in an extemporaneous event. WUDC debates are not designed to be contests of expert knowledge, but to be intellectual events where intelligent citizens can exchange arguments and ideas. It is important to set motions that debaters and judges can be realistically expected to have enough knowledge to conduct a meaningful debate. As the Berlin WUDC (2013) debater briefing puts it, “Judges assess which team did the best job at persuading them that the motion ought to be affirmed or rejected. They do this as the ‘ordinary intelligent voter’ and consider the strength

of the arguments that each team presents” (p. 1). The “intelligent voter” is a key element in WUDC as an extemporaneous event. The debate needs to be targeted at what broader audiences would be familiar with. This construct has been usefully defined in the Berlin WUDC (2013) briefing advice to debaters:

The ordinary intelligent person has the sort of knowledge you’d expect from someone who read newspapers occasionally, but not frequently or cover-to-cover. She is not a politics geek, but has a broad understanding of major world issues and movements in high-level terms, but does not know the detail of individual conflicts, regional bodies or anything but the very most prominent countries’ domestic situations. You should certainly make reference to facts and details the ordinary intelligent person does not understand, but you should explain rather than citing these examples, facts and countries. While she may not know much by some of your standards, the ordinary intelligent person is genuinely intelligent, and understands complex concepts once they’re explained. Where such examples are not explained beyond name-checking a country, judges should discount any material they do understand because the ordinary intelligent person would not (though there may be a small stylistic benefit to sounding well-informed even as the content is lost). Judges should be bold in applying this rule: it is unfair on other teams in the room not to. (p.4)

This “intelligent voter” as judge is very relevant to the extemporaneous nature of most political discussions that we confront in everyday life. Judges are encouraged to view the debate from a political framework, and not as judges of a formal speaking event. The Berlin WUDC (2013) describes this role as:

We as judges should remember that we are not

aiming to evaluate who was cleverest, neatest or funniest, but who best used their cleverness, neatness and funniness to persuade that the policy was a good or a bad idea. The best way to do that is simply to address oneself towards debates as if there are real policies at stake and see who best persuades that the policy should or shouldn’t be done. This is the only reason we use the term “voter.” The ordinary intelligent voter: attempts to evaluate logically what the best thing to do is, using as inputs the arguments made by the teams, persuaded by a variety of tools which are not strictly logical, such as, style, neatness, clarity, etc. and their inverses. Critically, the ordinary intelligent voter is actually open to persuasion. (p.4)

The role of the judge in a WUDC debate is well suited to the extemporaneous nature of the activity and its relevance to everyday political and civic communication. Debaters are able to engage in a “reality check” on what they know.

Other relevant tests have been developed for WUDC motions. Shengwu Li (2012) has done some groundbreaking work on this. Li’s guidelines have been used by several tournaments, including the 2013 Berlin WUDC tournament and the 2013 US Universities Debate Championship. They include (p.2):

1. Test motions for depth. Those setting motions should be able to locate five logically consistent and persuasive arguments for each side.
2. Neither side should have a “silver bullet argument” (one that overcomes all others in shifting the decision to one side or the other).
3. Test motions for balance – Those drafting the motions should be willing to take either side of the motion if their only goal was to win the

debate.

4. Make models and plans for the proposition team fairly obvious to avoid the debate being sidetracked by arcane definitions and models or plans.

Guidelines one, two and four are relatively new to the topic composition process, and reflect the different needs of WUDC debating. Beside the issue of depth that has already been discussed, the idea of avoiding a “silver bullet” argument is important. In a room with four teams if there is such an argument it is hard not to give the first place ranking to the team that effectively deploys it. The fourth guideline is also important in WUDC debates. Models and plans need to be fairly obvious or else in the early debates (where teams of mixed abilities are debating) the first proposition team may make serious mistakes that impact on the performance of the other teams in the round, especially the second proposition team.

Many, but certainly not all, have used these techniques for writing and reviewing motions. It is hoped that by centralizing these ideas that there will be better motions for all debaters in the WUDC format. Likewise, as American educators enter into participation in WUDC debates, a radically different argumentative environment will confront them, where there are many different needs and tensions. It is hoped that these guidelines can help Americans embrace WUDC debating fully and with more awareness. Learning from our international colleagues can be a bit challenging for American academics, as unlike American debating, which is located within academic disciplines with a tradition of publishing, those in the international WUDC community tend to be transitory members of the community and do not memorialize what they have

learned through publication. It is hoped that this essay might be a small step in helping to bridge this gap.

The differences in how motions are developed for WUDC debate will involve a major shift in practice, theory and emphasis for USA debating. The sites of motion construction will have to multiply, the number of people involved in motion building will have to increase, and the standards used to develop motions will have to change. The motions will have to be specifically crafted for this extemporaneous debate event. These changes will have to happen rapidly as the format grows in the USA and, indeed, around the world. The move to WUDC debate that many American schools are making (some adding it and some replacing other formats) will necessitate a change in orientation towards the subjects of the debates themselves. It is hoped that this summary of the current literature and contemporary practice can be useful, resulting in better motions and better debates.

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